

Credibility & Counterarguments

Workbook 2 - Apply - Focused practice

Directions

Treat each item as close-choice practice. Preserve scope, certainty, and the exact job of each piece of evidence.

Exercise 1

A city report cites a national environmental laboratory for water-quality testing methods and a neighborhood resident for the claim that "the river is safe for swimming everywhere."

Task: Which evaluation is best?

- A. Both sources are equally strong for both claims.
- B. The laboratory is well matched to testing methods; one resident is weak evidence for a systemwide safety claim.
- C. Residents can never provide useful evidence.
- D. National laboratories know every local condition automatically.

Exercise 2

An employer proposes compressed workweeks. A critic says customer coverage may fall on Fridays. The employer replies that a pilot staggered employees' off-days and Friday response time stayed within the normal range.

Task: Why is the response relatively strong?

- A. It addresses the exact objection with pilot evidence rather than denying the concern abstractly.
- B. It proves every future Friday will be identical.
- C. It ignores customer coverage.
- D. It relies only on employee preference.

Exercise 3

A school board considers a new bus route. A transportation engineer estimates travel time using route data; a parent argues the route will “probably be unsafe” without citing any incident or design information.

Task: Which statement best evaluates the sources?

- A. The engineer is stronger for travel-time estimates; the parent's safety concern may be worth investigating but is not yet well supported.
- B. The parent is automatically stronger because parents care about safety.
- C. Both claims are equally supported.
- D. Engineers cannot evaluate routes.

Exercise 4

A proposal admits that a new collection program will cost more in its first year, then argues that equipment is a one-time purchase and provides three-year cost projections.

Task: What strategy is the writer using?

- A. Conceding part of the objection and responding with longer-term evidence.
- B. Ignoring the objection.
- C. Attacking the opponent personally.
- D. Changing the subject to an unrelated benefit.

Answer reasoning

Check your reasoning, not only your answer.

For every question, compare your reasoning with the explanation. If you missed the item, identify the exact step where your reasoning changed the source or used evidence for the wrong job.

Exercise 1

Best answer: B. The laboratory is well matched to testing methods; one resident is weak evidence for a systemwide safety claim.

Why: Credibility depends on the specific claim and the source's access to relevant evidence.

Exercise 2

Best answer: A. It addresses the exact objection with pilot evidence rather than denying the concern abstractly.

Why: The response matches the objection and provides direct performance evidence.

Exercise 3

Best answer: A. The engineer is stronger for travel-time estimates; the parent's safety concern may be worth investigating but is not yet well supported.

Why: It distinguishes source fit from the importance of the concern.

Exercise 4

Best answer: A. Conceding part of the objection and responding with longer-term evidence.

Why: The writer acknowledges the short-term cost instead of denying it, then limits its force with relevant projections.

Mistake check

For every miss, label the reason: wrong claim, evidence mismatch, too broad or too certain, reasoning gap, source or format confusion, or rushed reading. Then write one sentence explaining what you will check next time.